

SAUDI ARABIA

PRE-TOURNAMENT ANALYSIS • WORLD CUP 2026

GROUP H

SPAIN • URUGUAY • CAP-VERDE

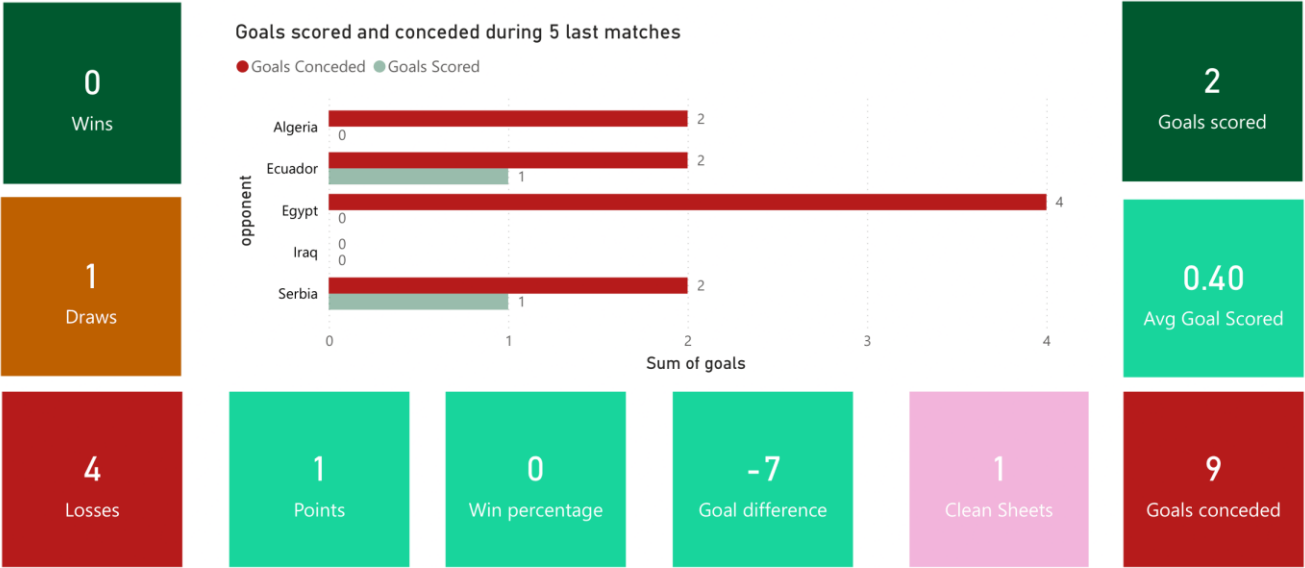


SAFF



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player	position	age	club	key_stat	squad_status
Salem Al-Dawsari	Attacking Midfielder	34	Al-Hilal	108 caps · 8G+8A SPL 25-26 · Rating 7.55 · Top 98% xA SPL	Undisputed captain · Heartbeat of the squad
Sultan Mandash	Winger	31	Al-Hilal	1st intl goal vs Ecuador 31/05 — came off bench · KSA's only pre-WC goal	Impact sub · Supersub threat
Saud Abdulhamid	Right Back	26	RC Lens	2G+8A Ligue 1 · Coupe de France · UCL 2026-27 · Extended to 2029	First-choice RB · Only European-based player
Musab Al-Juwayr	Central Midfielder	22	Al-Qadsiah	6G+11A SPL · Rating 7.81 · Saudi Player of the Season 25-26	Starting XI · First-choice starter
Firas Al-Buraikan	Striker	26	Al-Ahli	Top scorer qualifying · Goal in AFC Champions League final 2026	First-choice striker · Clinical finisher

SPAIN

21/06 • VERY DIFFICULT

FIFA

#2

URUGUAY

15/06 • VERY DIFFICULT

FIFA

#16

CAPE VERDE

27/06 • DECISIVE MATCH

FIFA

#68

GOAL: LOW LEVEL BLOCK VS SPAIN/URUGUAY - 3 PTS VITAL VS CAPE VERDE TO QUALIFY FOR
ROUND OF 32

FULL SQUAD (WITH ABDULHAMID + AL-SAHAFI)



1-2
ECUADOR



1-2
SERBIA



0-4
EGYPT



1-0
COTE D'.



0-0
IRAQ

ARAB CUP (SQUAD SAUDI LEAGUE ONLY - WITHOUT ABDULHAMID AND AL SAHAFI)



0-0
EAU



0-1
JORDAN



2-1
PALESTI.



0-1
MOROCCO



3-1
COMOROS

1W 1D 3L, 3 GOALS SCORED, 8 CONCEDED WITH THE FULL SQUAD. THE 4-0 VS EGYPT IS ALARMING. BUT CONTEXT MATTERS, KSA LED BOTH SERBIA AND ECUADOR BEFORE COLLAPSING IN THE SECOND HALF. THE REAL ISSUE ISN'T QUALITY, IT'S GAME MANAGEMENT. A TEAM THAT COMPETES FOR 60 MINUTES BUT CAN'T CLOSE OUT GAMES.

VS SPAIN (FIFA #2)

LOW BLOCK 4-4-2 / 4-5-1, DEFEND DEEP, COMPACT LINES, SEEK ONE QUICK COUNTER

VS URUGUAY (FIFA #16)

SAME APPROACH , BIELSA'S PRESS = MAX DANGER, ABSOLUTE DISCIPLINE AND COMPACTNESS

VS CAPE VERDE (FIFA #68)

HIGH PRESS POSSIBLE , ONLY MATCH WHERE KSA CAN IMPOSE THEIR GAME AND DOMINATE



DONIS: APPOINTED 24/04/2026 - ONLY 7 WEEKS BEFORE WC

KNOWS THE PLAYERS VIA SPL BUT ZERO TOURNAMENT EXPERIENCE WITH THIS SQUAD, KEY RISK.



4-2-3-1 CONFIRMED VS ECUADOR. KANNO + AL-KHAIBARI AS DOUBLE PIVOT SHIELD THE DEFENSE AND FREE SALEH AL-DAWSARI AS THE CREATIVE #10. ABDULHAMID IS THE MAIN ATTACKING THREAT FROM RIGHT-BACK. WHEN IT WORKS: FAST TRANSITIONS THROUGH AL-DAWSARI. WHEN IT BREAKS: FULLBACKS PUSH TOO HIGH - EGYPT EXPLOITED THIS RUTHLESSLY (4-0).



S. AL-DAWSARI

AL-NILAL • 34

108 CAPS • 86+88

RATING 7.55 • CAPTAIN

DECISIVE GOAL VS ARG 2022



ABDULHAMID

AC LENS • 26

26+88 LIGUE 1

COUPE DE FRANCE + UCL

2026-27

ONLY EUROPE-BASED •

EXTENDED TO 2029



AL-BURAIKAN

AL-AHLI • 26

TOP SCORER QUALIFYING

GOAL IN AFC FINAL 2026

CLINICAL FINISHER

AL-DAWSARI IS THE HEARTBEAT, WITHOUT HIM KSA DON'T FUNCTION. AT 34, HE CARRIES THE CREATIVE BURDEN OF THE ENTIRE TEAM. ABDULHAMID BRINGS A EUROPEAN DIMENSION NO ONE ELSE IN THIS SQUAD HAS, HIS OVERLAPPING RUNS AND CROSSING QUALITY FROM RIGHT-BACK ARE SAUDI ARABIA'S MOST RELIABLE ATTACKING PATTERN. AL-BURAIKAN IS THE FINISHER BUT NEEDS SERVICE , HIS MOVEMENT IS SHARP, HIS GOALS IN QUALIFYING AND THE AFC FINAL PROVED HE DELIVERS ON BIG OCCASIONS.

ONE TO WATCH



MUSAB AL-JUWAYR

AL-QADSIYAH • 22 Y

66+11A SPL 25-26

RATING 7.81 • SAUDI PLAYER OF SEASON

YOUNGEST IN WC SQUAD

19 CAPS • 6 INTL GOALS

ONE TO WATCH



SULTAN MANDASH

AL-HILAL • 31 Y

THE IMPACT SUB - CAN CHANGE A GAME IN 20 MINUTES. PROVED IN PRE-TOURNAMENT WHAT SUPERSUBS DO AT WORLD CUPS.

AL-JUWAYR IS THE MOST EXCITING SAUDI PLAYER SINCE AL-DAWSARI EMERGED. SAUDI PLAYER OF THE SEASON AT 22, HE HAS THE ENERGY AND TECHNICAL QUALITY TO BREAK OPEN GAMES. MANDASH PROVED IN ONE CAMEO VS ECUADOR WHAT HE CAN DO - THE IMPACT SUB WHO SCORED THE ONLY KSA GOAL IN PRE-TOURNAMENT PREPARATION. IN A GROUP THIS DIFFICULT, SUPERSUBS WIN MATCHES.



GEORGIOS DONIS - APPOINTED

24/04/2026

SYSTEM CONFIRMED

VS ECUADOR

FORMER AL-HILAL, AL-WUHDA, AL-FATEH, AL-KHALEEJ COACH IN SPL - KNOWS THE PLAYERS. 4-2-3-1 CONFIRMED. DEFENSE FIRST. VERY LITTLE TIME TO IMPOSE HIS STYLE BEFORE WC.

KSA STRENGTHS

SQUAD COHESION WITH 25 OF 26 PLAYERS FROM THE SAME LEAGUE, THEY KNOW EACH OTHER DEEPLY. DEFENSIVE DISCIPLINE WHEN THE BLOCK IS SET. PROVEN GIANT-KILLERS MENTALITY (ARGENTINA 2022). DONIS KNOWS THE SPL INSIDE OUT.

KSA WEAKNESSES

FINISHING IS THE CRITICAL ISSUE - DATA CONFIRMS IT. COACHING CHANGE 7 WEEKS BEFORE THE TOURNAMENT CREATES TACTICAL INSTABILITY. OVER-RELIANCE ON AL-DAWASARI AT 34 IN NORTH AMERICAN HEAT ACROSS 3 MATCHES. BENCH QUALITY DROPS SHARPLY AFTER THE STARTING XI.

VS URUGUAY (FIFA #16)

15/06

BIELSA'S 4-4-2, WORLD-CLASS MIDFIELD TRIO (VALVERDE, BENTANCUR, UGARTE), AGGRESSIVE PRESSING, PHYSICAL INTENSITY. STRENGTH: COHESION AND MENTAL TOUGHNESS. WEAKNESS: SQUAD DEPTH BELOW TOP TIER. KSA'S KEY: LOW BLOCK, SURVIVE THE FIRST 30 MINUTES, ONE COUNTER ON VALVERDE'S SPACE.

VS SPAIN (FIFA #2)

21/06

DE LA FUENTE'S TIKI-TAKA EVOLVED - FASTER, MORE VERTICAL. RODRI BACK FROM INJURY AS MIDFIELD ENGINE. YAMAL ON THE RIGHT IS UNSTOPPABLE ON FORM. SPAIN'S QUALITY IS IN A COMPLETELY DIFFERENT BRACKET. KSA'S KEY: 4-5-1 LOW BLOCK, LIMIT TOUCHES IN THE BOX, MAKE IT 0-0 AT HALF-TIME.

VS CAPE VERDE (FIFA #68)

27/06

BUBISTA BUILT A HARD-TO-BEAT DEFENSIVE STRUCTURE - ORGANISED, HIGH FITNESS, NOTHING TO LOSE. CAPE VERDE WON THEIR QUALIFICATION GROUP AHEAD OF CAMEROON. THIS MATCH IS WIDE OPEN - A CAPE VERDE WIN IS A GENUINE POSSIBILITY. KSA'S KEY: 3 POINTS OR GO HOME. NO EXCUSES.



PRE-WORLD CUP VERDICT

REALISTIC GOAL

THE DATA IS HONEST: ONLY 39.9% CHANCE OF ADVANCING IN OPTA'S 25,000 SIMULATIONS. SPAIN AND URUGUAY ARE A DIFFERENT LEVEL. THE CAPE VERDE MATCH ON JUNE 27 IS THE KEY - IT'S THE ONLY REALISTIC ROUTE TO QUALIFICATION. BUT KSA HAVE DONE THIS BEFORE. THEY BEAT ARGENTINA IN 2022 - THE EVENTUAL CHAMPIONS. SALEM AL-DAWASARI IS A TWO-TIME AFC PLAYER OF THE YEAR AND HE HAS SHOWN HE DELIVERS ON THE BIGGEST STAGE. BEAT CAPE VERDE. SURVIVE SPAIN AND URUGUAY. THEN ANYTHING IS POSSIBLE.

FOOTBALL WITHOUT DATA IS JUST OPINION. HERE'S WHAT THE NUMBERS SAY ABOUT THE GREEN FALCONS BEFORE GROUP H - THEIR TOUGHEST WORLD CUP DRAW IN A GENERATION.



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